Gmail John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com>

Matcher Case Study - Astrid Pharma

9 messages

Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com> Tue, Oct 13, 2026 at 4:02 PM
To: John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com>, Kristian Mueller <kristian@bwcoconsulting.com>
Cc: Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com>

Hi John,

Here is a case study for Astrid, which we reviewed together, but I thought it would be worthwhile to review the fidelity of the grants that the Matcher lists and note grants that the Matcher doesn't catch. Thank you!!

Sameera, please feel free to chime in if you think any of my findings are incorrect re: Astrid's capabilities.

Overall notes: One thing that would be useful is if the grant list contained the link to where the main solicitation lives for the grant opportunity.

How I used it: searched all agencies, put the aspect similarity threshold at .6, upped the top matches to 50 instead of 25. This gave 14 results, which are reviewed below. I have attached the CSV output as well and it should match these 1-14 (or rather, 2-15 on the excel doc).

1. **Radiopharmaceuticals (36C24126Q0363)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/5b466c5a65154b7b8f4598cd1179f113/view
b. Review: Not a match. This is a VA supply buy, not R&D. It is also a notice of intent to award sole-source to Cardinal Health.
2. **NIAID SBIR/STTR omnibus**
a. Link: Parent SBIR (R43/R44): https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/359671 | Parent STTR (R41/R42): https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/359757
b. Review: Yes, this is a match. It fits the chlamydia oral mucosal vaccine, but the AI rationale doesn't apply.
3. **BARDA BAA AOI 8.1.2, More Effective Vaccines**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/8170c4735df64714adb2d1f8ce8671b1/view (BAA-23-100-SOL-00004, open through Sept 25, 2028)
b. Review: Partial match. A path exists if Astrid puts a BARDA-priority antigen on BioCapZ and develops single-dose or mucosal data.
4. **Nuclear Medicine Radiopharmaceuticals (36C25926R0074)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/2bee2f57e77647afaf5a089763203ab4/view
b. Review: Not a match. Cheyenne VA delivery contract for Tc-99m kits and Xe-133, not R&D.
5. **Radiopharmaceuticals (36C25626AP3509)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/1951c885f0ac46ffa34c5f585b59b90d/view
b. Review: Not a match. VA supply buy, not R&D, and already awarded to RLS USA.
6. **Japanese Encephalitis Vaccine (SPE2DP-26-R-0001)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/ccdad6ced74440a2a2679e68202ab40d/view
b. Review: Not a match. This is a DLA purchase of an already-licensed vaccine, and the offeror must hold FDA approval.
7. **F18 Radiopharmaceuticals (36C24726Q0232)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/966695dc01f94c17a259ac23b65c46c1/view
b. Review: Not a match. VA supply buy (sources sought for Atlanta VA). It also requires an established commercial radiopharmacy with 10+ years of operation.
8. **F18 Radiopharmaceuticals (36C24726R0060)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/85b61aa9f4094a63a3fd36ad93ce01d9/view
b. Review: Not a match. VA delivery contract, set aside for service-disabled veteran-owned businesses.
9. **GUIDE (JPL CBRN Enabling Biotech, W911SR-25-S-GUIDE)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/7d3f105a09734cbb9b3742fbaca5998f/view
b. Review: Probably not a match because it requires a multi-attribute ML design platform.
10. **NIH Highlighted Topic: GLP-1s and nutrition**
a. Link: https://grants.nih.gov/funding/find-a-fit-for-your-research/highlighted-topics (search the page for "GLP-1")
b. Review: Not a match. It is about GLP-1 users and supplements, not oral delivery technology.
11. **BARDA AOI 1.3, Flexible Manufacturing**
a. Link: Same BARDA BAA as #3: https://sam.gov/opp/8170c4735df64714adb2d1f8ce8671b1/view

b. Review: Not a good fit. It requires gene-to-IND in under 6 months, at least 2 CBRN threats, and over 1M doses manufactured, which is out of reach for a small business at the R&D stage.

12. **DOE Genesis, Scaling the Biotechnology Revolution**
a. Link: https://www.bwcoconsulting.com/fod/doe-genesis-mission-sbir
b. Review: Not a match. It covers biomanufacturing instead of therapeutics.
13. **Radiopharmaceuticals (36C25725726P0423)**
a. Link: https://sam.gov/opp/f0a55eabb542467dbde74ad370cc04ec/view
b. Review: Not a match. VA supply buy, not R&D, and already awarded sole-source to Panhandle Nuclear Rx.
14. **BARDA engineering design phase**
a. Link: https://www.bwcoconsulting.com/fod/barda-production
b. Review: Topically okay, but entry requires MRL 6, which is beyond Astrid's current stage.

Then, I went and searched for other opportunities using Claude, ChatGPT, and grants.gov. I uploaded their January 2026 slide deck that is currently in our internal folder as the topic overview. So here are topics it should've caught but didn't (all of these aren't necessarily a perfect fit – fit strength indicated in the review -, but would be better than the supply buy options):

1. **NIH SBIR/STTR Omnibus, NCI track (colon cancer PET/theranostic)**
a. Link: Parent SBIR (R43/R44): https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/359671 | Parent STTR (R41/R42): https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/359757
b. Review: Strong match. The oral PET imaging data in HCT116 colorectal tumor models is published (*Eur J Pharm Sci*, 2023), and it's the most reviewer-ready evidence Astrid has. STTR with UC Davis as the research partner is the natural structure, since Dr. Cheng is UC faculty and the core IP is licensed from UC Davis. Next standard due date is January 5, 2027.
2. **NIH SBIR/STTR Omnibus, NIDDK and NEI tracks**
a. Link: Same Parent SBIR/STTR announcements as above
b. Review: Partial match. NIDDK fits the oral insulin and oral GLP-1 programs, but both are listed at the earliest discovery stage, so preliminary data may be too thin for a competitive Phase I right now. NEI fits the subretinal delivery data (BioCapZ internalized into photoreceptor cells in mice). These are better as second or third applications after the NCI lead.
3. **NIH Highlighted Topic: Nanotechnology for Diagnosis and Treatment (NEI/NCI)**
a. Link: https://grants.nih.gov/funding/find-a-fit-for-your-research/highlighted-topics (search the page for "nanotechnology")
b. Review: Match. This isn't a separate solicitation. It signals NEI and NCI interest in nanoparticle delivery and diagnostics, and Astrid can cite it in an omnibus application to show alignment with institute priorities. It covers both the NCI and NEI tracks above.
4. **NCI Toward Translation of Nanotechnology Cancer Interventions (TTNCI) R01**
a. Link: https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/357748
b. Review: Partial match. It supports advanced preclinical nanomedicine for cancer diagnostics and therapeutics, which fits the colon cancer theranostic. Because it's an R01, it works best with Dr. Cheng/UC Davis as the lead applicant and Astrid as a partner rather than as a small-business award. Confirm for-profit eligibility before pursuing. Open through November 2027.
5. **USDA NIFA SBIR/STTR Phase I**
a. Link: https://www.nifa.usda.gov/grants/programs/sbir-sttr (no open Phase I notice right now)
b. Review: Match for the ASF DNA vaccine under the Animal Production and Protection topic. It's the only federal SBIR path for the veterinary lead. The current Phase I cycle appears to have closed, so set up Grants.gov alerts for the next one. Note that live ASF virus work in the U.S. is limited to high-containment federal facilities, so the study design would need to avoid live-virus challenge or justify foreign work.
6. **USDA AFRI Foundational and Applied Science Program (Animal Health priority area)**
a. Link: https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/360205
b. Review: Partial match. Private-sector entities are eligible, and the Animal Health area fits the ASF vaccine. Program-area deadlines vary within this RFA, so check whether the Animal Health deadline has already passed. If it has, plan for the FY2027 RFA.
7. **USDA NIFA SBIR/STTR Phase II**
a. Link: https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/364020
b. Review: Not eligible. The topic fits ASF, but only prior USDA Phase I awardees can apply. Due November 17, 2026. It becomes relevant only after a Phase I award.
8. **NCI SBIR Innovative Concept Award (FY2027)**
a. Link: https://www.highergov.com/contract-opportunity/national-cancer-institute-nci-small-business-inn-75n91026r00109-p-260d9/

b. Review: Closed (late September 2026), and the fit was weak. The topics focused on pediatric and rare cancers, and Astrid's FAP targeting data is a stretch for that framing. Worth watching for the FY2028 cycle next summer.

9. **NIH Commercialization Readiness Pilot (CRP) and Phase IIB Strategic Breakthrough**
   a. Link: CRP: https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/359669 | Phase IIB: https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/359758
   b. Review: Not actually eligible yet. Both require a prior NIH SBIR/STTR Phase II award. They become follow-on funding later.
10. **NSF SBIR/STTR, Scientific Instrumentation Pilot**
    a. Link: https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/362551
    b. Review: Semi fit. NSF generally doesn't fund therapeutic drug delivery, and this pilot targets scientific instruments and experimental platforms. Selling BioCapZ kits as a research reagent is the only possible angle, and it's a stretch. Due November 4, 2026.
11. **NSF SBIR/STTR (standard program, Project Pitch)**
    a. Link: https://seedfund.nsf.gov/project-pitch/
    b. Review: Partial match. This is different from the instrumentation pilot I flagged earlier. A pitch could work only if it's framed around the nanocapsid engineering itself: encapsulation, stability, and manufacturing reproducibility. Any therapeutic, vaccine, or disease-specific framing would likely be redirected to NIH or USDA. The pitch is short and low-cost, so it's worth trying as a secondary track. Confirm the pitch window is open.
12. **NIH/CDC SBIR Contract Solicitation (NCI contract topics)**
    a. Link: https://sbir.cancer.gov/small-business-funding/contracts
    b. Review: Watch list. NCI releases defined contract topics once a year, and some past topics have covered imaging agents and nanotechnology. Fit depends on whether next year's topics include targeted imaging probes or cancer nanomedicine. The solicitation typically posts in late summer, so there's nothing to apply to now.
13. **NIH Parent SBIR, NIBIB track**
    a. Link: PA-27-100 on SBIR.gov: https://www.sbir.gov/topics/12563 | Grants.gov: https://www.grants.gov/search-results-detail/359671
    b. Review: Partial match. NIBIB funds platform technologies that apply across many diseases, which suits a BioCapZ-as-imaging-platform proposal. NIBIB rejects single-disease projects, so the colon cancer work fits NCI better. NIBIB would make sense only for a platform-level imaging proposal. Sending draft aims to the NIBIB small business office first is advisable.
14. **NIH Parent SBIR, NHGRI and NIGMS tracks**
    a. Link: Same PA-27-100 links as above
    b. Review: Weak match. NHGRI's small-business interests center on genomic technologies, and CRISPR delivery is a stretch unless framed as a research tool. NIGMS supports broadly enabling technology, but Astrid's preliminary data is application-specific. I'd only pursue these after talking to the program officer.
15. **Watch list (no link yet):** FY2027 CDMRP announcements, especially the Peer Reviewed Cancer Research Program for the colorectal theranostic. These usually release early in the calendar year.

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John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com> Tue, Oct 13, 2026 at 4:04 PM
To: Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com>
Cc: Kristian Mueller <kristian@bwcoconsulting.com>, Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com>

Thank you for this! Using it to make some tweaks behind the scenes!
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Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com> Tue, Oct 13, 2026 at 4:14 PM
To: John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com>

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Rachel Crawford reacted via Gmail
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Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com> Fri, Oct 16, 2026 at 11:35 AM
To: Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com>
Cc: John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com>, Kristian Mueller <kristian@bwcoconsulting.com>

Hi Rachel and John,

I have a few comments on the latest updates:

1. Non-matches: The first list indicates "not a match" for most entries. Why are these included if they aren't a match?
2. Client Preferences: The client noted they prefer to avoid long wait times and bureaucratic SBIR/STTR grants. They are open to national, international, and foundation-type grants instead.
3. Sorting: Shouldn't the matcher prioritize the best options so top matches are easy to find?

At this point, I feel like I have to spend more time on understanding and doing more research. Help!

Best regards,

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Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com> Fri, Oct 16, 2026 at 11:43 AM
To: Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com>
Cc: John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com>, Kristian Mueller <kristian@bwcoconsulting.com>

Hi Sameera, regarding number 1, that output was not from the matcher - that was my review of them to help John incorporate what is not actually a good match into the system. Hopefully that helps with understanding!

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Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com> Fri, Oct 16, 2026 at 11:47 AM
To: Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com>
Cc: John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com>, Kristian Mueller <kristian@bwcoconsulting.com>

Ohh got. Thanks, Rachel. So, we don't have a list yet. Sorry if I am being naive here.

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Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com> Fri, Oct 16, 2026 at 11:50 AM
To: Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com>
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The second list, which comes after a short paragraph jump of me noting so, are some of my recommendations that I think the Matcher would be good to include but were not included - but let me know if you disagree.

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Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com> Fri, Oct 16, 2026 at 11:52 AM
To: Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com>
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PS they are not all the best fits in my second list, but still better than the supply buys - wanted to include a range to show the nuances of why something is/is not a good fit, so for example it may topically be a good fit but here's why they're not eligible, etc.

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Kristian Mueller <kristian@bwcoconsulting.com> Mon, Oct 26, 2026 at 1:23 PM
To: Rachel Crawford <rachel@bwcoconsulting.com>
Cc: Sameera Panchangam <sameera@bwcoconsulting.com>, John Gahn <john@bwcoconsulting.com>

John,

let us know if you need clarification of what is what or for any other items that we should dig into so we can make the Matcher's output more in-line with what Claude give us, i.e. what it should be.

Best,
K

Kristian Mueller
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